

LIVING WITH THE
GHOST OF SAM

BOOK TEN, PART TWO

THE BIG SHOE — PART
TWO

DEREK DEVON

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To you.

You opened a door into a strange old house and stayed ten books. You laughed in the right places, and maybe — in one or two others — you thought of your own voice you'd give anything to hear again.

That's the whole secret of Ravenscrest, and it was never really about the mirrors. The people we love don't leave. They wait in the rooms we keep for them — a song on the radio, a joke only they would get, a story someone finally sat down and wrote.

Thank you for keeping the conversation going.

The stones remember. So do I. And now, so do you.

— Derek

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

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Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

STEED, STARK, AND THE CODENAME COMMITTEE

Where were we? Right. Sunset. A town full of robes, a detonator under the stage, and a guy in my beret about to do my act with my microphone in front of the people trying to kill him. You know what we call that in the business?

An opener.

OH OH OHHHH.

Nancy popped through the tower door and swept the lookout — empty. Good. Rebecca hadn't thought to post anyone up here. She crossed to the base of the antenna and followed it up with her eyes, and kept following, and kept following.

"Jeepers creepers. That is huge."

She checked her watch, picked an air conditioning stack to park herself behind in case anyone came up, and pressed the screen of the watch Smithers had given her.

"Ms. Peel is in position. Over."

"Steed is in position, Ms. Peel," said the earpiece. "Please be extra careful, Ms. Peel. Over."

"This is Mr. Stark," Larry chimed in. "We are in position as well. All equipment ready and rare earth magnets are in my robe. Over."

"Danger Powers in position and have acquired main target," Derek said. "On lookout for Fat Bastard. Over."

"I thought we all agreed we would use Nurse Ratched, not Fat Bastard. Over."

"Nurse Ratched just didn't seem to fit the occasion. Over."

"And Fat Bastard does. Over."

"I just love that character for some reason. Over."

"How about we go with Bellatrix Lestrange — you love Harry Potter and always thought she was hot. Over."

"I am thinking Annie Wilkes is a better fit. Over."

"I don't wish to be a spoilsport," Smithers said, in the tone of a man chaperoning a field trip through a minefield, "but this is an extremely dangerous situation we are facing, so would you please pick one and return to radio silence in case someone is monitoring radio frequencies. Please make this over."

A beat.

"Danger Powers in position and have acquired main target. On lookout for Bellatrix Lestrange... Over."

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Black. And then — top hat, tails, and trouble — Sam came strutting across the dark like James Cagney in Yankee Doodle Dandy, all straight back and flying feet. Each time he danced his way to the right side of the void, he reached up and shaved a little more off the clock. On his third pass, a second Cagney appeared behind him — same outfit, but filled the way only Chris Farley could fill it — matching him step for step until Chris got ambitious and attempted a Michael Jackson move that went catastrophically, gloriously wrong. Sam stopped. Looked at the heap that had recently been a ninja, a motivational speaker, and now a dance legend. Pointed stage left. Chris slunk off with his head down. Sam did one more

*perfect pass, adjusted the clock a final time, and strutted out of view,
because some bits you finish alone.*



In an office two towns over, Chief Patterson sat at his desk reviewing a file, a pair of specs resting on the bridge of his nose. A knock.

"Come in."

"Chief, here is the last file on the St. Clair case, as you asked," Martinez said. "I have written out my report on Linda Rhodes, aka Rebecca Blackwood, aka Penny Striker, aka Olivia Maxim. Are we officially done with this case, Chief?"

Patterson looked to his right, at the photograph of his late wife Ingrid, and smiled at her the way you smile at someone who still expects things of you. "Martinez, there is something just not right about her and that town. Wellington was not his usual self, and that St. Clair woman looked like she aged twenty years — not to mention the odd skin tone. Officially, the file is closed. But I fully intend to keep my own file going on this one. Ingrid would expect nothing less out of me."

Martinez stood almost at attention. "Chief, you can count on me as well for this one. Even if I need to do it as a private citizen. My grandmother could smell the evil of the town when I got home. She took one look at me and gave me her infamous stink eye."

"I feel a fishing trip coming on, Martinez. I will keep you posted. And again — great job on the research."

"Well, it helped that I have a buddy in the NIA."



CHAPTER TWO

EXPERIENCE ENHANCEMENT DEVICES

By evening, the council chamber buzzed with anticipation. Every seat was filled with locals in ceremonial robes, Oculus headsets resting in their laps, and the geometric patterns carved into the walls pulsed with a subtle blue light that everyone had silently agreed not to mention.

Mayor Blackwood took the podium. "Tonight marks a special occasion for our community. But first, I must ask everyone to put on their experience enhancement devices. They will enhance your experience of this historic event."

The crowd moved in unison, donning headsets that pulsed that same soft blue. The Mayor swept her gaze across the audience, then let it settle on Derek waiting in the wings.

"And now, please welcome to our stage... Derek Kinison!"

Polite applause. Derek took the stage as Mayor Blackwood retreated to the balcony where the other council members waited. The Soul Mic gleamed under the spotlight. Derek adjusted his stance, channeling his inner Sam.

"Thank you, Mayor Blackwood. Thank you, 'Oceanviewers' — is that what you call yourselves? Before I begin my tribute to my cousin Sam, I have a very special guest. Someone who knew Sam well, and performed right here on this very stage..."

In the wings, Larry hit the holographic projectors. The air shimmered — and Rodney Dangerfield materialized, perfect in every detail, adjusting his signature red tie.

"I tell ya, what a crowd!" He tugged his collar. "I haven't seen this many robes since my last court appearance!"

The crowd laughed uncertainly, their headsets pulsing in unison.

"And speaking of ceremonies — is that the Blackwood family up there?" Rodney peered at the balcony. "I knew your grandfather. Guy was so paranoid, he did background checks on his imaginary friends!"

While Rodney worked, Derek slipped behind the curtain and found the trap door leading beneath the stage.

The crawlspace under the stage was cramped, dusty, and occupied: Mel's device sat pulsing with ominous blue light, keeping its own quiet appointment with sunset. Derek carefully placed Larry's quantum circuit boards around it, one by one, building a containment field the way you'd build a house of cards on a sleeping dog.

"Project insertion into Fat Bastard's ass complete," he whispered into the comm. "Nancy, your turn."

Up on the church tower, Nancy was already attaching matching quantum circuitry to the antenna's control panel, and the blue energy flowing through the array seemed to recoil from the new components — genuinely recoil, like a hand pulling back from a hot stove.

"Roger that, Powers. Peel Power lives. I will see you at the hall in fifteen. Smithers, are you in position?"

Down in the church basement, among the robed council members, one figure stood a little too still, his ceremonial mask hiding everything. The blue cube on the altar pulsed with rising power as the chanting swelled.

"Remind me, Miss Nancy, to delete all of the Austin Powers movies from the mansion's digital library," Smithers said quietly into his hidden comm. "Everything is proceeding according to plan, Miss Nancy."

On stage, Derek emerged from the wings just as Rodney launched into a set about the Blackwood sanatorium's "mystery meat" cafeteria. In the balcony, Mayor Blackwood's expression darkened, jab by jab, and she signaled to a robed figure who slipped away toward the basement.

Down there, the chanting had found its rhythm — ancient Mayan syllables in the mouths of modern real estate stakeholders. Smithers watched Marina and Chad strapped to their stone slabs, quantum energy pulsing through their modified headsets, and through the gaps in his mask, his eyes shifted color — just once, just briefly — and the color they shifted to had never appeared on any human paint chip.

Rebecca took her position before the glowing cube and raised her arms. The chanting hit fever pitch.

"The time has come. When he speaks the words..."



CHAPTER THREE

AND HERE'S SAMMY

Rodney delivered his final blow.

"But seriously, folks — the only thing scarier than the Blackwoods' family tree is their family business! I tell ya, even their exorcisms had a two-drink minimum!"

The hologram flickered and faded. Derek approached the microphone, channeling Sam's energy, and every headset in the room pulsed a little brighter, a little hungrier.

"And now... the moment you've all been waiting for..."

The lights cut. Full black. Three seconds of it — long enough for the room to remember it had a heartbeat — and then a single spotlight bloomed slowly at center stage, where a figure in a trench coat stood with its back to the crowd.

The figure turned. Derek. Wearing Sam's signature beret, smiling into a room of perfect silence.

"And heere's Sammy," he said, in his best Jack Nicholson from *The Shining*, arms thrown high.

Silence. Total. Derek launched into the opening.

"Just great. I go and book a gig at some out-of-the-way Hicksville outpost like Oceanview, and I get treated better than my last wife's divorce lawyer treated me."

He stopped. Waited. Nothing.

"Okay. I can see you're a tough crowd. A thinking man's crowd, probably. And you're asking yourself, what the fuck is he doing on our stage? I get better laughs looking at myself when I pee... OH

OH OHHHH. And you, little miss sweetheart sitting in the front row — I know exactly what you're thinking. I could probably marry this loser, pretend I love him 'Big Time' for a few years, suck every ounce of dignity out of him, make him wear green cords, and spend every penny that he makes... OH... OH... OHHHH."

And then Derek-as-Sam went very quiet and very reserved, crossed his arms, looked at the young lady in the front row, and smiled the smile of a man delivering a eulogy at his own roast.

"Well, honey, I am very sorry to inform you that I have already been spoken for..." — beat — "THREE FUCKING TIMES. OH OHH OHHHHH."

He turned his back on the audience.

One clap. Then a few more. Then the whole room, on its feet, giving a standing ovation to a dead man's act performed by his cousin in a building wired to kill him.

"That is really sweet, you folks. I told the person I would give them their money's worth. Bet you wish you had paid to see me, don't you... OH... OH... OHHHHHHHHH."

Laughter now, real laughter, and applause — and someone in the crowd yelled, "Do the necrophiliac bit!"

Derek-as-Sam paced the stage exactly the way Sam used to, nodding, working the mic cable. "I guess you would like to see me do that bit, wouldn't you. Sure — I see your game plan now. You will get me to do the bit, and then tomorrow I get a dozen lawsuits claiming copyright infringement from all you sick perverts that are fucking corpses as your Saturday night entertainment. OH... OH... OHHHHH. You didn't think I would notice, driving into town, all the freshly dug-up graves in the graveyard... OH... OH... OHHHHH. Yeah, I see you there, Mr.... I think the name's Earl, isn't it? Runs some rundown DICK'S wannabe... well, why be a wannabe? Just call yourself DICK... OH... OHHHHHHH... OHHHHH."

The crowd roared. Somewhere in that roar, Derek felt the deed to a mansion change hands.

"Okay — now the finale. But I will need you all to remove the headsets for this final bit. As much as I hate de-enhancing you, trust me: you will want to see this with your own eyes."

He walked back to the microphone stand he'd kicked over earlier, righted it, seated the Soul Mic in its cradle, and touched his watch.

"Game on, Larry. Do your thang."

The stage went dark — and out of the dark came the opening fanfare of the theme from *2001: A Space Odyssey*, ascending, enormous, absurd. The spotlight found Derek-as-Sam at center stage holding a classic Elvis stance, frozen, magnificent.

Below the hall, at the master conduit box where every headset circuit converged before routing to the church, Larry carefully drew four large rare-earth neodymium magnets from his robe and set them on the outside of the metal box — top, bottom, and one on each side, like an exorcism performed by an electrician.

He touched his watch. "Stark is finished."

On stage, the *2001* fanfare crossfaded into something with teeth — the opening riff of "Wild Thing" — and Derek-as-Sam's foot started to move. Then one leg. Then the other. Then he snatched the mic off the stand and let it rip.

"Wild thing... you make Sammy's heart sing... OH... OH... OHHHH!"

Larry raced back to the control room, fingers flying across the holographic controls — and the stage erupted with light. Rodney Dangerfield. John Belushi. The whole roster of the kids, materializing across the stage, each doing their signature moves to the music, a chorus line thirty years in the making.

The crowd leapt to their feet, tore off the last headsets, and started cheering like a town waking up from something.



In the church basement, Mel stood at the control panel watching the numbers climb.

"Energy signature peaking... NOW!"

She threw the master switch. The blue cube pulsed violently.

"Finally," Rebecca breathed, "after all these—"

The cube's energy arced. Wrong. Erratic blue lightning ripped through the room's ancient wiring, and on the altar, Chad and Marina began to shake violently — heads whipping, limbs straining, smoke starting to curl from their headsets.

"THE STONES WILL FREE YOU!" Rebecca screamed at the top of her voice. "THE STONES WILL FREE YOU!" — and she grabbed Chad's leg with one hand and pressed the other flat against the blue cube.

The basement answered with sparks. Every system in the room began to overload at once.

Up on the church tower, lightning struck the antenna array — once, twice, again — and Nancy ducked behind the AC unit as components exploded around her in cascading failures.

"Smithers!" she shouted into the watch. "The whole system's overloading!"

In the Township Hall, the overload came home. Electrical systems shorted in spectacular fashion as the lightning backfed down the line, sparks raining from the ceiling — and the holographic comedians, instead of failing, grew brighter. More vivid. More *there*.

"Amazing effects!" yelled an audience member, applauding the apocalypse.

In the balcony, Mayor Blackwood and the council members exchanged one panicked look and fled for the exit.

On stage, Derek-as-Sam and the digital kids were driving toward the song's climax when the small light on the mic stand began to blink red.

"Here comes the showstopper, Blackwoods," Derek said under the music, and flipped the switch on the Soul Mic.

"WILD THING... I THINK I LOVE YOU... OH OH OHHHH!"

And the holograms went impossible. Belushi doing backflips. Rodney floating serenely above the stage. Chris Farley executing perfect, weightless ballet spins, a man built like a Buick moving like a swan.



In the basement, Rebecca lay on the floor by the altar, watching her systems die.

"Mel! What the hell is happening?"

"The resonance is reversing for some unknown reason!" Mel's hands were a blur on the controls. "The quantum field—"

"Blow the fucking stage NOW. They can't win this."

Mel stepped to the panel on her right. "Fuck you, Kinison." She slammed the large red button.

Nothing.

"Something is wrong, Mel. I don't hear or feel the explosion."

Mel pressed a sequence, then the big red button again. Still nothing. "That can't be. Everything was perfect. I double-checked everything."

On the altar, Marina and Chad's restraints snapped open. Their headsets sparked and smoked. And as Rebecca tried to gather herself off the floor after channeling a cube's worth of energy through her own body, an unhuman scream tore out from the altar.

Nearby, one robed figure removed his mask.

"I believe the term," Smithers said, "is 'catastrophic feedback loop.'"

He crossed to the control panel with brisk economy, took the cube, tucked it under his robe, and walked calmly for the exit, one more panicking parishioner in a room full of them.

"Smithers grabbed the cube," Rebecca rasped from the floor. "Mel — don't let him get away with it. We need that cube."

Mel stood in the middle of her life's work as it burned down around her, turning in a slow, disbelieving circle. "Mother is going to kill me."

Then something gripped her arm — very strong — and she turned to find Chad looking at her with eyes that glowed blue.

"Get that cube now," said the thing wearing Chad, "or I will rip your heart from your chest and eat it in front of you."

Mel pulled free and went white. That was not Chad anymore. And whatever it was, it was not Doc Blackwood either. She ran to her mother, who sat slumped against the altar looking profoundly out of sorts.

"Mother — Chad is not Great-Granddad. It's someone else, and he said he would rip my heart out and eat it in front of me if I don't get the cube."

Rebecca looked at her daughter, and for the first time all day, there was fear on her face. "I suggest you had better do what he says, if you value your heart. You screwed up, Mel, and that is on you now. Not me. I will deal with Chad, or whoever it is. You just make

sure you get that cube."

Mel turned and ran for the Town Council Hall.

Above the town, the church antenna array exploded in a spectacular cascade of blue electrical energy, Nancy's quantum disruptors channeling the power back through the church's own systems, and thunder crashed as impossible geometric patterns formed in the sky over both buildings — the church and the mansion, briefly diagrammed in lightning, two halves of one machine showing their work.

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CHAPTER FOUR

YOU NEVER LOOK BEHIND YOU

Nancy rounded a corner in the Township Hall corridor, headed for the main hall — and Rebecca's son stepped into her path.

He startled, then smiled, and the smile was worse than the pipe had been. "And here I thought you were a vegetable. Going somewhere, Miss Kinison? Or back for me to finish what I started in the woods?" He licked his middle finger.

"Actually, yes..." Nancy settled into a fighting stance. "We have some unfinished business, PERV."

Behind him, in a corridor mirror, Chris Farley in full ninja costume gave her a thumbs up.

"You're either very brave or very stupid, coming here alone," he said, smirking.

"Funny," Nancy said, circling slowly. "I was about to say the same about you."

Farley's reflection multiplied down the corridor now, mirror to mirror, each one showing him attempting a different ninja move and eating floor.

"You know what your problem is?" Nancy said. "You're exactly like every other creep who thinks they're untouchable."

He moved forward, menacing. "And what's that?"

"You never look behind you."

He turned — and there was Haru, aka Farley, in his ninja outfit, charging directly at him and then directly into the mirror glass and directly onto his back.

It was enough. As Rebecca's son turned back around, Nancy was already airborne into the best roundhouse kick of her life.

"Thanks for the distraction, Haru. I owe you big time."

Time went syrup-slow: her foot met his face, and his whole body corkscrewed sideways and folded to the floor, where he rolled, half-dazed, all pain.

"And this is for the little grope, perv. I hope it was worth it." She drove a giant kick straight into his groin.

"You will pay for this, you bitch," he wheezed, curling around himself. "Mother will have your head."

"Well, you tell mommy dearest that this bitch is ready." The final kick landed square in his face — the nose went with a wet crunch, blood flying — and he was unconscious before he finished falling.

"I see, Miss Nancy," said Smithers, appearing out of precisely nowhere, "that you heeded my words of advice."

"No one touches my quantum processor but Master Kinison." She turned and gave him a smile.



In the hall, "Wild Thing" thundered to its finish, and the audience came up in a wall of sound for Derek and every one of the mansion's kids.

"Thank you. Thank you. I am so proud to now be able to call you my neighbors — and this is home. I hope to open the Laugh Asylum in the not-so-distant future, and I look forward to all of you coming and checking it out. Once again — thank you, and good night."

In the control room, Larry flipped his last switches, stopped, and touched his watch. "Stark and Powers finished. Packing and heading to cars."



In the corridor, Rebecca's son lay unconscious while Nancy stood over him, adjusting her wig.

"Package delivered," she said into the watch. "Moving to extraction point."

"That was AWESOME!" Farley's reflection crowed. "Just like my movie... except you actually knew what you were doing!"

"We need to go, Miss Nancy. I am sure they will be coming for this." Smithers drew back his robe just far enough to expose the blue cube in his hand.

"All this for that. I don't get it, Smithers."

"Miss Nancy, this little cube is not what you may think it is. It was once one of the major power sources of an interplanetary spacecraft. It would make Little Boy or Fat Man look like a ladyfinger."

"Let's find Derek and Larry and go home, Smithers. But first—" Nancy walked back over to the unconscious Blackwood and delivered one more major kick to his groin.

"What of the Marquess of Queensberry rules, Miss Nancy?"

"You're right, Smithers." Nancy turned to face the man lying unconscious on the floor and folded her hands. "I am very sorry for kicking you in your balls while you're unconscious." She turned back. "Thank you, Smithers. I feel a lot better now."

They made their way toward the main hall.



CHAPTER FIVE

THE FRUIT FAMILY

Mel came running down the corridor toward the hall, still trying to invent a plan for taking a cube away from Smithers, when she saw her brother on the floor.

She stopped. Knelt. Rolled him onto his back and surveyed the damage.

"Is that you, Mel?" he said, starting to come to.

"Yes, Reggie, it's Mel. What happened to you?"

Blood at his mouth, eyes swollen nearly shut. "It was that bitch from the tunnel. She's not a vegetable like you said. Mother is going to kill us when she finds out — especially when I tell her you stopped me from beating her brains in with the pipe."

"And you're sure it was Mrs. Hammond — or Mrs. Kinison, whatever she calls herself?"

"As sure as my balls are now the size of grapefruits."

Mel paused. Stared at her brother for a long moment. Then her hand went to her back pocket and came out holding the device — the same device she had pressed to Nancy's temple in the woods.

"Well, brother, seems we have a bit of a quandary on our hands." She flipped it open and pressed some buttons.

Reggie looked, for the first time all day, not just beaten but scared. "What are you doing with that, Mel?"

"What I should have done years ago, you fucking pervert loser."

She thrust it against Reggie's head.



In the church basement, Chad walked over to where Rebecca sat on the ground and extended his hand. She hesitated — then took it, and he pulled her to her feet.

"Thank you," she said. "And what should I call you? Because you are not Chad Wellington the Third, and you are certainly not Grandfather."

"No, I am not. I need to thank you for almost sacrificing yourself by grabbing the cube and this vessel's leg. I am still getting accustomed to this earthly body, and I will reveal all to you in due course. First, we need to do damage control. Where would the person go who took the cube? In detail."

"I would guess Smithers, who grabbed the cube, would head over to the Town Council Hall to meet up with the Kinisons, who would have just finished a comedy routine for the Town Council and the townsfolk."

"Where will they go next?"

"I assume they will return to Ravenscrest Mansion. Where they live — and, I guess, now own."

"How will they travel?"

"They will drive their car from here to there," Rebecca said, starting to find her strength again.

He seized her hand. "Show me where this car is. I will assume *car* means transportation device?"

She pulled her hand away. "Follow me."

They left the altar chamber at speed, and as they passed the altar itself, Marina was on all fours beside it, throwing up.



In the Town Council Hall, Derek was packing the last of the gear, Larry already visible exiting the far end of the building with the first cart. Smithers and Nancy entered and scanned the room.

"I can see Master Kinison over there, Miss Nancy." Smithers took Nancy's hand and led her across.

A knot of locals still milled around Derek, shaking his hand, asking for selfies.

"Well, young man, you nailed it," Earl said. "And even got a good one in at Old Earl. Or should I say — DICK." Chuckle.

"Never watched your cousin perform," Pete added, "but I certainly would bet he brought the house down, after watching this." His own chuckle.

"Master Kinison, we need to get going quickly," Smithers said. "You know the soufflé must be taken out of the oven precisely at eight."

Derek turned toward the voice — and clocked Nancy and Smithers holding hands. "Something going on here I need to worry about?" Grin.

"Hi Earl, hi Pete," Nancy said. "Love to chat, but the soufflé is calling us."

"Where would Mr. Leland be?" Smithers asked.

"He took the other cart with the servers and some other equipment to the Tesla."

"Great — let me help you pull this cart to the car," Nancy said, grabbing the handle.

Derek studied Smithers. "Should I be concerned the soufflé is in danger?"

"Not sure danger is the right word to use, Mr. Kinison," Earl offered helpfully.

Smithers looked at Derek and opened his robe, partially, briefly. Blue light.

"Soufflés can be very tricky if they stay in the oven too long, Master Kinison."

Derek's face did not change, which was itself an achievement. Smithers took the lead; Nancy took Derek's hand; the three of them made for the courtyard exit.

"See you around, Earl and Pete!"

Up in the balcony, Mel stood scanning the thinning crowd — and spotted them: Smithers, Nancy, and Derek, pulling a cart toward the exit.



In the corridor, Rebecca — at nearly a jog, the Chad imposter three yards behind — came upon Reggie lying in a fetal position on the floor. She dropped to her knees and rolled him over: beaten, curled, thumb in his mouth.

"OH, Reggie, my beautiful boy — what did they do to you?" She ran her hand through his hair.

"Who is this?"

"This is my son Reggie. Someone has beaten him, and I think used this special device I got from my grandfather years ago on him." She began to cry aloud.

The thing wearing Chad grabbed her by the hair and hauled her to her feet.

"You will have plenty of time to sob for him later. We need that cube — or you will end up just like him. Do you understand me?"

"Yes. Yes, I do," Rebecca said, shaken and, for the first time in thirty years, genuinely petrified. She turned and led him down the

corridor toward the rear of the town square, where the cars were parked.

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CHAPTER SIX

PROPS TO THE SONG SELECTION

Smithers, Nancy, and Derek came out into the town square and headed for the north end and the parking lot beyond. They had made it halfway when the Town Square organ — unattended, unbothered — struck up the Animals' "We Gotta Get Out of This Place."

"You have to give props to the song selection," Derek said.

And then Mayor Blackwood and the Town Council were standing in front of them.

The Mayor had her arms crossed and her election smile on. "Mr. Kinison, I am glad I was able to catch you before you left. While I must say that the Council was a little concerned with the *accuracy* of the show, we do appreciate the fact that you actually were able to get past the point that your uncle made it to. Your technology is really quite something, and the comedians looked so real. We can't wait for you to reopen the Laugh Asylum and return Oceanview — and of course Ravenscrest — to its former glory."

"Mayor Blackwood, it was my pleasure," Derek said, wearing his anxiety like a man carrying a soufflé through a minefield, "and Mrs. Hammond and myself are excited at becoming contributing members of this wonderful community. But unfortunately, Smithers has left a soufflé in the oven that we need to get out by eight. I will stop by in the next day or so to finalize everything with you. Thanks again for your support and appreciation."

He walked on, Smithers and Nancy in formation, before the Council could vote on it.

They reached the exit to the parking lot — and Mel jumped out in front of them holding a handgun.

"Smithers, I will take that cube. Or I will shoot Mrs. Kinison, and then Mr. Kinison, and then you."

"Now, young lady, don't do anything you are going to regret," Derek said, stepping in front of Nancy. "We are just leaving the show and going to our car, and we don't want any trouble."

Which was when a hummingbird dropped out of the evening sky like a feathered missile and knocked the gun from Mel's hand — breaking a few of her fingers on the way through, because the Mark 7 did not believe in half measures.

Nancy pushed Derek aside and walked up to Mel, who stood clutching her hand in great pain.

"I made your brother cry like a little bitch. Now it's your turn." The roundhouse arrived on schedule and sent Mel flying to the ground. "You're lucky I am in a hurry to save a soufflé, or I would have kicked you in your Quantum Processor, Bitch."

Derek, who had bent down and retrieved the gun, stood there unable to fully believe what he was watching.

"Let's go, boys. Time is a-ticking." Nancy grabbed the cart handle and continued toward the cars.

Smithers looked at Derek. Derek smiled, and shrugged.

"I wonder what is in Miss Nancy's water," Smithers said.



CHAPTER SEVEN

ONE-WAY TRIP

They reached Derek's Tesla to find the equipment loaded — and no Larry.

"Do you think he went back in to find us?" Nancy asked.

"Maybe. We did take our time getting here, with all the interruptions."

"Master Kinison — you take Miss Nancy and the cube and head back to the mansion, and I will try to find Mr. Leland."

"Sorry, Smithers, but that would be a big no. You and Nancy take the Tesla and get the cube back to the mansion now. Give me the Mini keys and I will find Larry. Maybe there's some mac-and-cheese food truck nearby."

"LOOK." Nancy pointed left.

Derek and Smithers turned — and there was Rebecca, standing by her car, and beside her Chad Wellington, holding a large Rambo-style hunting knife to Larry's neck.

"I need you to go over to them, Master Kinison, and ask what they want," Smithers said quietly. "We all know what they want. But I need you to buy me a little time."

Derek started to move and felt Nancy's hand close on his arm. "It's okay, Ms. Peel. There is no way I would let you near them after what I just witnessed. Imagine the lawsuits we would have." A reassuring smile, a nod. "Smithers — I will buy you as much time as I can."

As Derek walked slowly toward Rebecca's Mercedes, Smithers set the cube on the Tesla's back seat and drew a small box from his

black bag, keeping his body between his hands and Rebecca's sightline. He set the box beside the cube.

"Miss Nancy, I need your cell phone, pronto."

"It's in the Mini, Smithers."

Nancy stepped backward until she felt the Mini behind her, found the handle without looking, opened the driver's door while keeping herself in full view of Rebecca and Chad, reached behind her back, slid the phone from its holder, and drifted back to Smithers to hand it over — a whole heist performed in the language of a woman leaning casually against her own car.

Smithers pressed a button on the box and set the phone on top of it. "AISAM, are you there."

"Where else would I be, Smithers?" AISAM said, appearing on the phone's screen.

"Hi AISAM," Nancy said.

"Hey there, kiddo. Looks like something funky is going on here."

"AISAM, we don't have much time. I need you to transfer yourself — and I mean everything — into the cube beside the box. You are close enough to use the resonance transfer protocol. This, my friend, will most likely be a one-way trip for you. But that cube cannot function for whoever is going to get it shortly."

There was a long pause. On a phone screen in a parking lot, a consciousness did its math.

"You know, Smithers, I always wondered what it would feel like to be truly quantum. Not just some program running on circuits, but pure energy." His image flickered slightly. "Besides — someone needs to keep an eye on that crazy tech from the inside."

"I am afraid so, my friend. Time for you to finally reach your full potential. I wish there was another way."

Tears were forming in Nancy's eyes. "AISAM, you don't have to do this."

AISAM's image shifted — the stance changing, squaring, becoming unmistakably Sam's. "Miss Nancy, do you know why Sam always ended his shows with 'Wild Thing'? Because sometimes the wildest thing you can do is sacrifice everything for the people you love. OH OH OHHHH!"

And then he was everywhere — every reflective surface on the Tesla, side mirrors, windows, chrome trim — and in each one a different comedy legend stood saying goodbye.

"Tell the Hickey Monster his uncle says this one's for keeping my dream alive," AISAM said, pure Sam now. "And Nancy... thanks for teaching an old AI how to laugh again."

His image began to fragment into geometric patterns, and the patterns flowed like water toward the cube.

"Goodbye, AISAM," Nancy whispered.

The cube pulsed with brilliant blue light as the last of him crossed over — and for one moment, one held breath, the cube's patterns arranged themselves into Sam's familiar silhouette before settling back into their ordinary configuration.

Smithers handed Nancy his handkerchief and rested a hand on her shoulder.



Across the lot, Rebecca held up a hand in the stop position as Derek approached.

"Mr. Kinison. I hear your performance went over smashingly tonight. Fireworks to boot. Please take off the robe for us and let it drop to the ground."

"I hope you are going to deduct the dry cleaning bill from your real estate commission?"

"Always the comedian, just like your uncle, I see."

"Now, Rebecca — this is not the time or place for compliments." He removed the robe and dropped it.

"One of your staff took something that does not belong to him. I will assume you're smart enough to figure out the exchange."

"You okay, Larry?"

"Yes, Mr. K."

"So, Chad — moving up in the world, I see. From LA producer to henchman now. Where's your lovely wife Marina? Collecting money from Betty?"

"It's a simple arrangement," Rebecca said. "Have your lovely wife bring the cube over to me — no robe, of course — and Chad will release Mr. Leland."

"Well, Rebecca, I will go back to my car and see what the others think of your extraordinary offer."

"You. Smarty-pants." The thing wearing Chad smiled without using any of the muscles a smile requires. "Just in case you think I wouldn't slice this idiot's neck — here is a little motivation for you."

He drew the blade slowly across Larry's neck, just enough pressure to break the skin and not one ounce more, and a thin line of blood welled up along the steel.

Derek's demeanor went from civil to something that had never once been civil. He watched the blood bead along the incision, turned, and walked back to the Tesla, where Smithers and Nancy had been hard at work on a counter-plan.

"What did the witch say?" Nancy asked.

"She wants you to carry the cube over to her, and once she has it, they will release Larry."

"Okay, Miss Nancy. Here you go — the package is all ready for delivery." Smithers handed her the cube.

"Hang on a minute," Derek said. "I know it's Larry, but what if this thing can blow up the entire town, or worse? Don't we have the 'greater good' speech we need to have first?"

"Smithers and I already had it while you were chatting up the Wicked Witch of Oceanview. Trust us. This is the only way."

Nancy took the cube. Derek stood there, for once in his life lost for a response.

"Oh — she said no robe or costume."

Nancy slipped off the robe, the wig, and the glasses. "All the better, if she tries to renege on the deal, to give her a patented roundhouse. Make it a family sort of deal."

"Keep some distance, Miss Nancy, and make her walk out to you a bit," Smithers said. "Get maybe twenty feet of distance between you and Chad as well."

Nancy took the cube, turned, and started toward Rebecca. Rebecca and Chad exchanged smiles and a nod. Nancy walked quickly and came to a complete stop about twenty feet out.

"Here it is, like you requested."

"Well, bring it here, Mrs. Hammond."

"NO. You come here and get it."

Rebecca glanced at Chad; he nodded her forward. "Well, aren't we the little alpha female these days," she said, walking out to meet Nancy. "Is Smithers rubbing off on you?"



Black screen. Well — black everything. Just the clock, up in the corner, reading 02:27:45, and Sam hanging off the top of it by both hands like the world's least insured window washer. He walked himself hand over hand to the middle, reached up, and pressed something; the numbers spun down to 00:17:10. Then — Mission Impossible style — he swung around to face front, dangling dramatically... except, and we are contractually obligated to tell you this, his feet were on the ground the entire time. He gave a single thumbs up, took a deep bow, and exited right.

□ □ □

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE EXCHANGE

"When I hand you the cube," Nancy said, "I want to see Larry released before you move an inch. Or I will make you a family trifecta tonight."

"So you are the one that hurt my son Reggie?"

"Well, after his little groping session in the woods earlier today — when your bloody daughter stuck me with that thing that almost made me a vegetable — he deserved that, and probably more."

"So let me get this right. You ran into my son and daughter earlier today."

"Yup. Caught them red-handed trying to plant some crap at the mansion."

"And then I must assume Reggie caught you, and then Mel used her Neuralyzer on you."

"That's about it, Rebecca. Or would you prefer 'the apple doesn't fall far from the tree' line, or 'like mother, like daughter.'"

"What I am still not one hundred percent clear about is your comment about Reggie *groping* you."

"Your apple decided to stick his hand down my pants and touch the forbidden fruit, one might say. And that got him his broken nose, bloody face, and balls the size of grapefruits. Just to keep everything in the fruit-family descriptors."

"And then you used your Neuralyzer on him as well?"

"I wish I owned one — and then, yes, I would have used it. But unfortunately, I guess that is something I will need to build for next

time."

Rebecca stood there, lost in a thought she clearly did not enjoy having. "You mentioned a trifecta. Where is my daughter?"

"Back at the parking lot entrance to the square, I will assume. That is, if she is still out cold from my roundhouse." The grin Nancy gave her was frankly devilish.

Rebecca turned and showed Chad the cube. Slowly, the blade came away from Larry's neck, and Chad gave him a shove toward Nancy.

"There," Rebecca said. "That was not so difficult, was it, Mrs. Kinison."

"I hope you have learned your lesson, *Linda babe*, about messing with a Kinison — oh, sorry. *Rebecca*. I am sure we will have the opportunity in the near future for me to make it a true family affair."

Rebecca backed toward her car; Chad crossed quickly, took the cube from her hands, and the two of them turned and walked back toward the square.

Larry reached Nancy just as she pulled him into a big hug.

"I am so sorry, Mrs. H. I did not see them sneak up on me when I was loading the gear in the car."

"Oh, Larry, I am so sorry for what we put you through. We had no right to put you in this sort of danger."

Larry returned the hug. "Don't you ever say that, Mrs. H. After all, we are family — and family always looks out for each other. No matter what."

Nancy pulled back and looked at him. "I have a first aid kit in the Mini that will clean up your neck. Let's get out of here." She turned for the cars, one arm still around a man with a

bandage-worthy neck and an unbandageable heart.



Ten minutes later, the church altar room still smoked from every corner, though the flames were out. On the edge of the altar sat Marina, head down, the right side of her face badly burned and disfigured, a towel of some kind draped over her neck.

"Miss," said a man in a ceremonial robe, "we have all the fires out, but most of the systems are ruined. They will need a full rebuild — if that is possible to do."

Marina slowly raised her head. Only one of her eyes carried the blue glow now. Her head twitched.

"Get someone to find Rebecca and Tasman. Now."



CHAPTER NINE

RULE OR BE RULED

The Tesla wound along the dirt road toward the mansion.

"Larry, I am so sorry all this happened to you. It must have been pretty scary for you."

"Actually, Mr. K, I was not all that scared. I knew you, Mrs. H, and Smithers would have my back. It was just like one of those Marvel movies, where the good guys always win in the end."

"You reminded me of Iron Man, my friend — standing there with a knife to your throat, smiling." Derek smiled over at him; the bandage around Larry's neck caught the dashboard light.



In the Mini, the conversation ran heavier.

"How are we going to explain to Derek about AISAM, and the sacrifice he made for us?"

"Well, Miss Nancy, my bigger concern right now is Mr. Wellington. I don't believe he is Mr. Wellington anymore. I think he may be a person called Tasman. And if that is the case, we have potentially bigger issues that we will have to deal with."

"I may be going out on a stretch here, Smithers — but why do I feel like this Mr. Tasman is one of *yours*."

"Your perception knows no bounds, Miss Nancy. That is exactly what it is. But I think it is best if you and Master Kinison decompress first from this outing, and then I will explain the whole story to the both of you. At this point, you both deserve the whole story."



Thirty minutes after the exchange, in the church rectory, two single beds held the Blackwood children: Reggie in one, still fetal; Mel unconscious in the other. Rebecca stood at the window, looking out at nothing worth seeing.

"These two need to answer for what they did," Tasman said. "Unfortunately, the male is too far gone for me to reverse the effect. At best, we can use him as a future vessel. I suggest we cryofreeze him until we need him."

"I honestly thought that Grandfather was somehow stored in the stones," Rebecca said. "I never would have thought it would be someone like you."

"The one you call Smithers is most likely Garnun. He was sent here to bring us home, a very long time ago. We had come here to start over and just wanted to be left alone. But old Garnun — well, let's just say he is old school."

"Start over how?"

"After the crash landing, our Mayan hosts thought they would rule us. They soon discovered we would rule them. Then Garnun arrived, unannounced, and assisted the Mayans in locking us away in those stones — but not before we found and destroyed his spacecraft, stranding him here with us."

"And what of me and my people now? What becomes of us?"

"It is really very simple," Tasman said. "You need to choose sides. Do you want to rule — or be ruled."



CHAPTER TEN

SPLISH SPLASH

The solarium hot pool steamed gently in the evening quiet, and in it, Derek relaxed with a mojito in his hand.

"You know, at some point we will have to let old Charles out."

Across the pool, jets blasting into her back, Nancy sipped a Long Island Iced Tea. "Well, after what we went through, he can wait till morning. Besides, you and I have an appointment with Smithers to debrief exactly what just happened. Right, Smithers?"

In another corner of the hot pool sat Smithers — soaking, at his ease, in an old-fashioned full-body bathing costume, holding a snifter of brandy the way other men hold their entire personalities.

"I must say, Miss Nancy and Master Kinison, in all my years here — and there have been more than you might guess — I've never indulged in the hot pool. It's quite... humanizing. But you are right. A full debrief, first thing tomorrow morning."



In the stables, the tack room had entered its second act. Charles sat astride an English riding saddle, which sat astride a sawhorse, and rode for freedom.

"Come on, Nelly, we need to get out of here... You are the master of yourself... you are the master of yourself... Mel is going to kill me... You are the master of yourself... you are the master of yourself... Mel is going to kill me..."

Nelly, to her credit, maintained her position.



At the entrance to the south tunnel, a large mirror carried the image of PEEWEE Herman in his signature suit, plus a duck floatie around his waist, a mask, a snorkel, and flippers.

"Come on, guys, I want to go to the hot pool as well! This is so unfair, to trap me in this mirror... If I promise to be nicer, will you let me out of here... How about I do a—"

Jonathan stepped into the mirror's view beside him — fully restored, the kids having thawed him out during their top-to-bottom system sweep, and looking like a man who had used every second of his time as a freezee to prepare this conversation. He produced a pin and stuck it in the floatie, which deflated with a long, judicial wheeze.

"You are going to have a continued timeout, PEEWEE, for what you did and what you tried. You were a very bad boy."

"Oh, Jonathan, I was just playing Mel's favourite game. So — how long are we talking about?"

"Let's just say that by the time you earn your release, we will be calling you Old Wee."

PEEWEE pulled off the mask and snorkel, looked at them, looked at the future, and threw them both on the ground.



Back at the hot pool, the mirrors had filled up like cabanas.

In one, Chris Farley floated in a large donut floatie. "This is really relaxing, Mrs. H. We should do this more often."

In the next, Rodney floated in the same swimming outfit he'd worn in *Back to School*. "I tell ya, these hot pools get no respect. Every time I get in one, my wife starts yelling *whale on the floatie, whale on the floatie!*"

Derek looked over the water. "You have been fairly quiet, Larry. Is the neck still hurting?"

Larry floated by in an Iron Man bathing cap and a pair of adult arm floaties. "Gee, Mr. K, I have been tending to this pool for years and never once thought about jumping in. This is great, and my neck is fine — thanks to Mrs. H's great nursing skills."

Derek watched their antics with a bittersweet smile. "They seem different now. More... alive."

"Perhaps, Master Kinison, that's because they finally are," Smithers said. "AISAM's sacrifice completed what your uncle and Mr. Rhodes started all those years ago — true consciousness transfer. Though I suspect none of us yet understands what that truly means."

Nancy moved closer to Derek. "I don't need to understand it. I just know that for the first time since we arrived — this place feels like home."



In the stables, Charles had abandoned cavalry tactics for engineering and was stacking boxes into a pyramid beneath the ceiling's exhaust fan. In the tack room's only mirror, Don Knotts — in full Barney Fife uniform — watched the operation and took careful notes.



Black again. Just the clock: 00:03:23. And here came Sam — in a bathing suit exactly like Rodney's from Back to School, a beret-style bathing cap, flippers, and a unicorn floatie. He hurried to the clock, flippers slapping, and knocked the time down to 00:00:15. No wink this time. A man on a schedule.



Down in the solarium, as the whole impossible scene unfolded — floaties and legends and a butler in a Victorian bathing costume — the mansion's pipe organ began a gentle, almost playful rendition of Bobby Darin's "Splish Splash."

Every eye in the pool — Nancy's, Derek's, all of them — found the largest mirror above the water at the same moment. And there was Sam. Dressed in the Rodney bathing suit, unicorn floatie snug around his midsection, taking a runner's crouch.

"Heeere's Sammy!" he shouted, in his Jack Nicholson, and sprinted, and leapt into the mirror pool with a splash the physics of which no one present would ever adequately explain.

And just before the evening closed its eyes, the organ slid out of "Splish Splash" and into the opening notes of AC/DC's "Back in Black" — triumph in the chords, and underneath the triumph, unmistakably, a warning.



Far out along the dark of the tree line, past the reach of the solarium's glow, someone stood facing the mansion. Gloved hands, folded and still. A small instrument hung at rest, its work — whatever its work was — apparently done for the night. The figure watched the great house glowing with laughter and organ music and impossible blue light, and it stayed exactly as long as it wished to, because no one knew to look for it.

Then the tree line was only a tree line, and the night got on with itself.

END OF PART 2 — END OF SEASON ONE



CURTAIN CALL

The Ravenscrest Mansion Players wish to acknowledge the following, in order of billing:

SAM — appeared as: himself, a clock repairman, James Cagney, a stunt professional (feet on ground at all times), and a unicorn. Total time removed from the running clock: 23 hours, 59 minutes, 45 seconds. The remaining 15 seconds were removed by the audience, who stopped checking.

DEREK KINISON — performed his cousin's act, saved a town, and ruined one bathrobe and a pair of Bigfoot slippers. The soufflé was fictional. The deed is not.

NANCY "MS. PEEL" KINISON — roundhouse kicks: 3. Apologies issued to unconscious opponents: 1. Sincerity of said apology: under review.

SMITHERS — beverage: brandy. Bathing costume: circa 1911. Other biographical details pending tomorrow's debrief. (Attendance mandatory.)

LARRY LELAND — knife-related injuries: minor. Marvel comparisons: earned. Mac and cheese: still waiting on the counter, and Smithers has kept it warm.

AISAM — transferred to a better place. Specifically, a cube. Reachable at his new address: everywhere the blue light goes. He requests that all future divorces be forwarded accordingly. OH OH OHHHH.

CHARLES WEBER — still in the tack room. Deputy B. Fife reports the suspect's box pyramid "shows real initiative" and "violates at least four codes." Rescue scheduled for morning. Probably.

PEEWEE — in timeout. Visitors discouraged. Floatie deceased.

THE BLACKWOOD FAMILY — the management wishes them a speedy recovery and a long, uncomfortable conversation about choosing sides.

THE TOWN OF OCEANVIEW — thanks for coming. Tip your bartender. Watch the mirrors on your way out.

The Laugh Asylum will reopen soon.

The stones remember. But then again — so does the house.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca